Not all reports by European travellers, however, were fictional. With the sudden expansion of the Mongol empire in the thirteenth century, the Arab stranglehold was finally broken and a few Europeans did genuinely travel to the east. The best known of these is Marco Polo. He is today remembered for his travels along the Silk Route to China and his stay at the court of Kublai Khan. However, he returned home by the sea route through South East Asia around 1292. On the way, he visited the ports of southern India and has left us extensive descriptions of what he saw. He tells us of bustling ports that exported pepper and imported horses, of Hindu temples and rituals, of diving for pearls, of a royal harem with 500 concubines, and even of a popular and wise queen who ruled an inland kingdom that produced diamonds (probably Kakatiya queen Rudrama Devi of Golkonda).[5]

Polo's facts and Mandeville's fiction both fired the European imagination. As the Renaissance took hold in the fifteenth century, European scholars opened their minds to the knowledge of classical civilizations. The works of Ptolemy were revisited and there were attempts to draw maps of India based on his descriptions. The Ptolemaic maps are a strange construct. Since no maps had survived from classical times, they were drawn purely by reading a text. Therefore, the Ptolemaic maps miss out on basic facts that would have been so obvious to Ptolemy himself that he did not dwell on them in his text. For instance, the maps do not show India's coastline as a peninsula but as a long east–west coast. Furthermore, the texts were over a thousand years old by the time they were being used to re-construct India's geography. Thus, they prominently mark places like Taxila that had disappeared over a millennia earlier. Such was the state of knowledge when the Portuguese decided to look for a way around Africa.

FOLLOWING VASCO

The Portuguese were the first European country to invest heavily into the systematic mapping of the world's oceans. Prince Henry the Navigator, the king's younger brother, became a patron of cartography and exploration. Through the fifteenth century, the Portuguese explored the west coast of